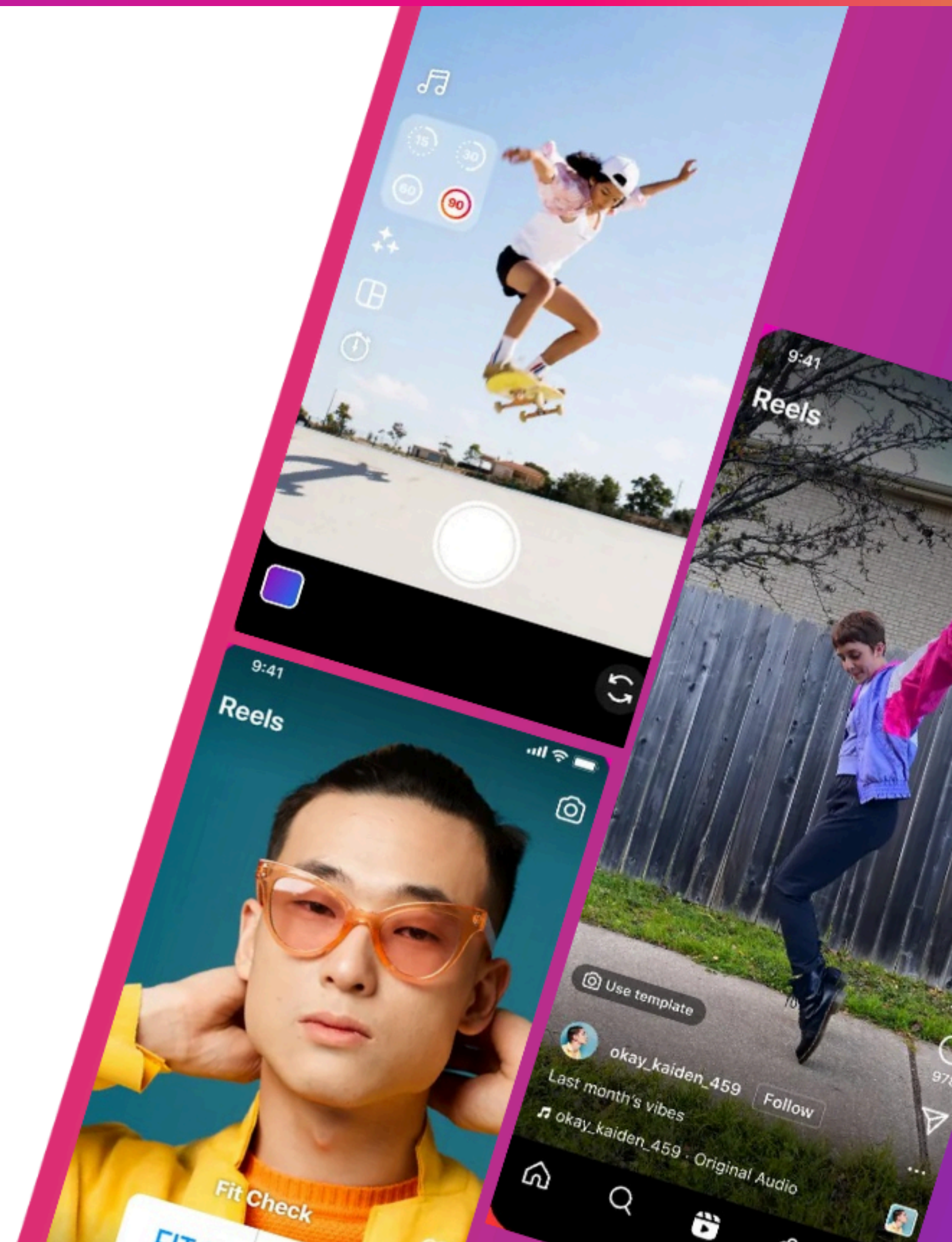




Instagram

Product Teardown & Feature Proposal

Activating zero-post Indian Instagram users to create their first Reel by removing psychological friction and lowering entry barriers.



Company Overview



Founded in 2010 by Kevin Systrom & Mike Krieger. Acquired by Meta in 2012. Now the world's leading visual social platform, operating across photos, short-form video, Stories, and in-app commerce across 100+ countries.

Mission "To bring you closer to the people and things you love"

Key Figures

GLOBAL SCALE

Daily Active Users

500M

Reels Played Per Day

200B+

Estimated Annual Ad Revenue

\$65B (2024)

INDIAN SCALE

Daily Active Users

130M

Average Time spent per day

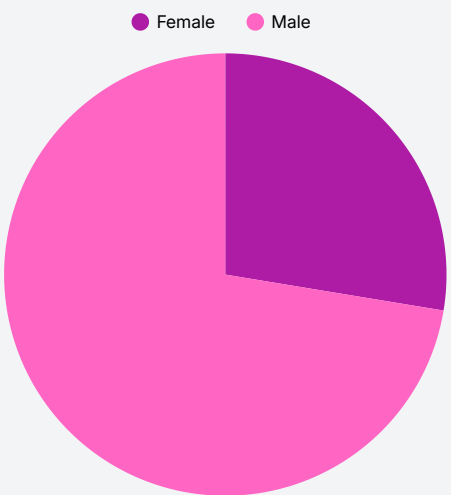
32 min

Reels Share of total share time

70%

DEMOGRAPHICS

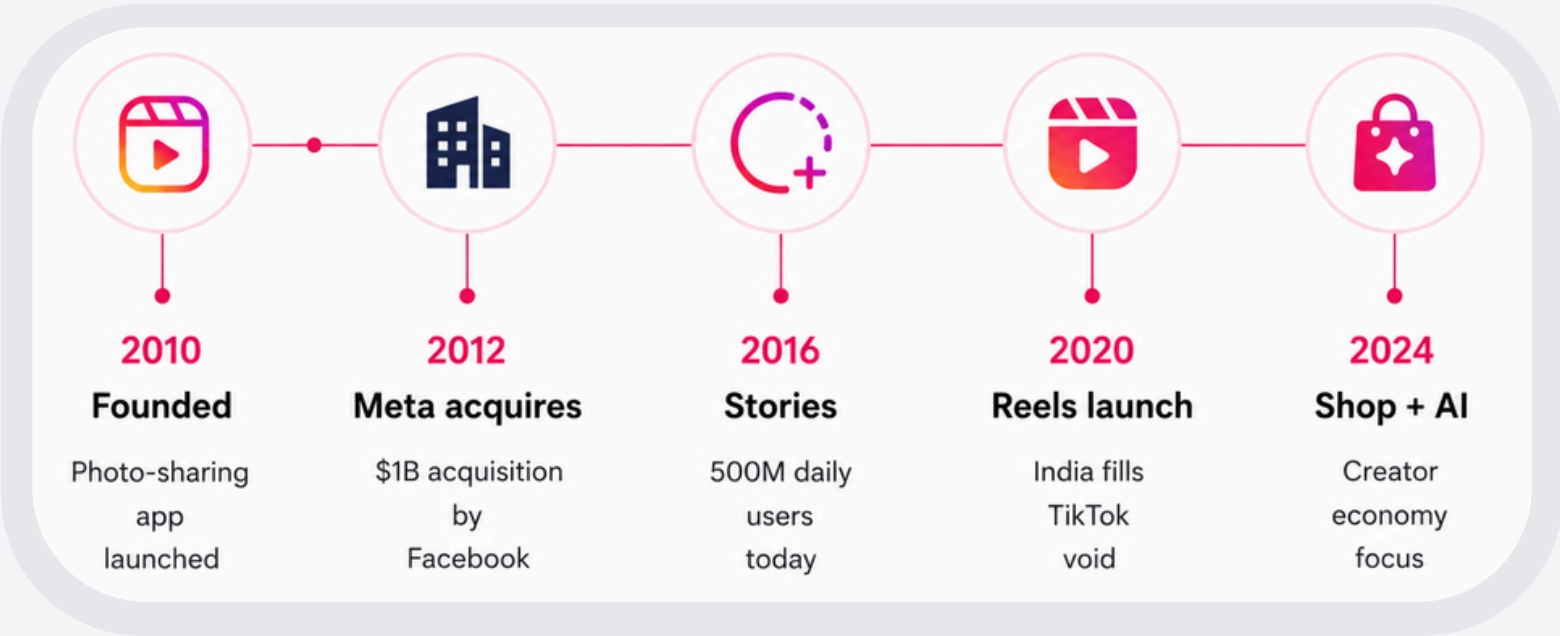
Gender Split in India



Dominant age group in India

18-34 yrs

Growth Timeline



Instagram Reels

A short-video feature for creating, watching, and sharing content, full-screen vertical videos, 15–90 seconds long, edited with built-in music, effects, and filters.

"The best place on Instagram to reach people who don't follow you."



Launched **August 2020** , built on the back of Stories, IGTV, Shopping & Live

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

Why Instagram launched Reels?



Staying Competitive

Countering TikTok’s video momentum



Monetization

Drawing influencer & brand ad spend



Retaining Users

Keeping attention inside Instagram



TikTok’s Ban

150M+ Indian users needed new home

REELS FOR USERS

- Skews Gen Z- built for quick, engaging short-form video
- Surfaces content through algorithm-based recommendations
- Drives discovery of favorite influencers
- Fuels participation in trends like dance challenges

“Reels has become my go-to source of inspiration... It’s very addictive, though.”

- Preet, User

REELS FOR INFLUENCERS

- Spans categories: beauty, fashion, fitness, travel, comedy
- Surfaced through the Explore feed to reach new audiences
- Built to grow follower counts and audience reach
- Opens doors to brand partnerships & sponsored content

“Reels is a fantastic way to showcase my talent... connect with my followers on a whole new level.”

- Ishika Sahni, Influencer

90 – 9 – 1

THE INTERNET’S PARTICIPATION RULE

Roughly 90% of users lurk, 9% contribute occasionally, and just 1% create regularly. With 414M Indian users opening Reels multiple times a day but only a sliver ever posting, that’s the gap this product needs to close.

2018 – MID 2020
The IGTV era

Long-form vertical video in a separate app

150M+

TikTok users absorbed on day one

2021 – 2022
Feature expansion

Duration stretched 15s → 90s. Remix, Collab tools, and creator bonuses drove virality loops.

1.8B MAUs

>50% of time spent

~1%
Stories-to-IGTV click-through

AUG 2020
The pivot & Reels launch

Short-form video embedded natively in Instagram, built on the Stories stack.

×2 rate
Reels shares grew QoQ in 2022

2023 – PRESENT
Reels dominance

Reels becomes the platform engine. AI-powered discovery drives DAUs. India is the #1 market globally.

Overview

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3 CORE BLOCKERS

Privacy/Judgement Fear

- 54% think twice before liking or engaging publicly
- 44% avoid liking from their main account
- 1 in 3 maintain a separate "finsta" for private engagement

[Source: Kantar / IFSO India Study, 2024](#)

Editing Friction

- App crashes frequently during editing
- Videos get blacked out or fail to play
- Heavy memory consumption slows creation

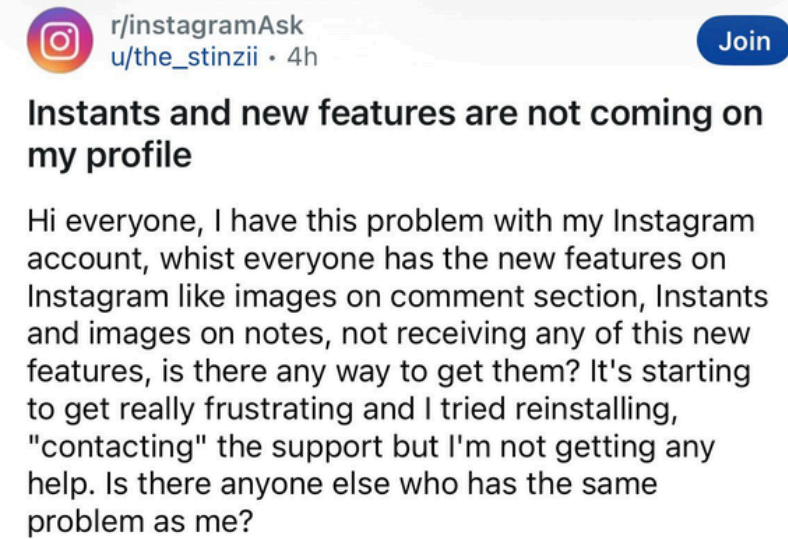
[Source: Play Store Reviews](#)

No Reason to Post

- Infinite-scroll feeds encourage passive consumption
- Posting feels risky due to fear of judgment
- No strong incentive to create or share

[Source: Lurker Psychology Study + Reddit threads](#)

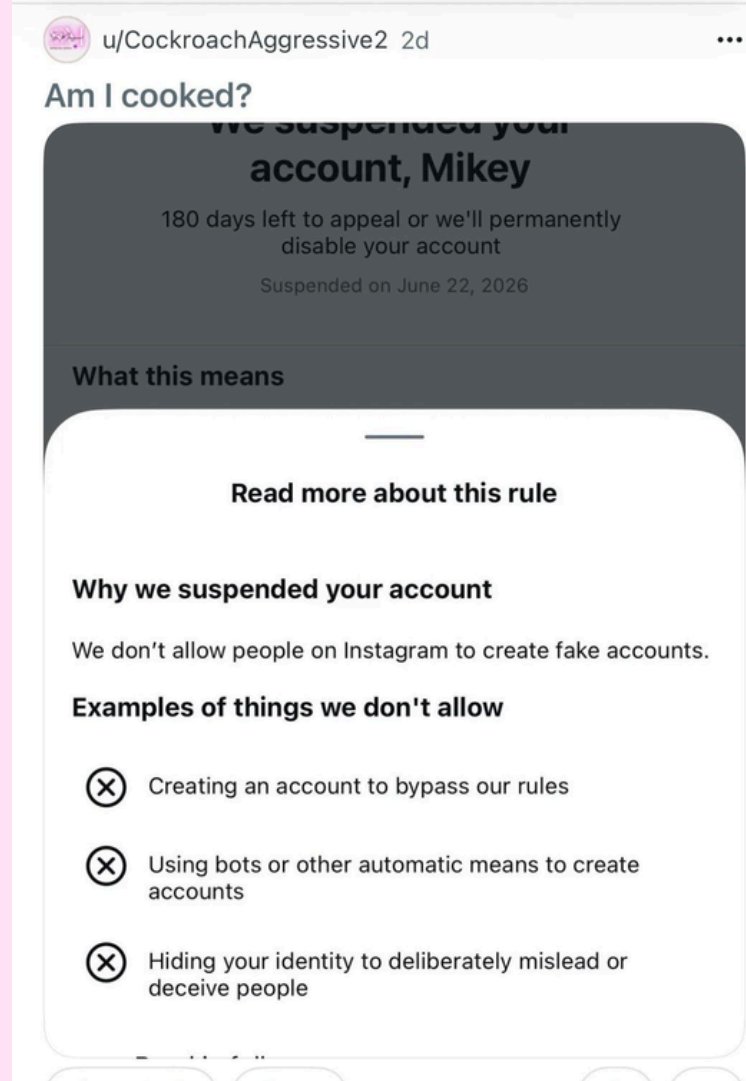
Evidence Snapshots



Dynamic Subtitles and Crashing in bet...

★★★☆☆ 13 Mar · IndianGamer_ChowWow

Please bring feature of dynamic subtitles which makes subtitles placed all over the screen and keeps the viewers more engaged . This will make life easier on edits. Secondly your app keeps crashing in between edit or simply goes to the initially points when there...



As a content creator I really hate using Instagram these days. Only felt disappointed after putting much effort in each content.

- ✗ Not reaching the right audience
- ✗ Unfollows are more which is unusual
- ✗ Less reach , Less followers, More unfollowers that Instagram does, not 1000 people will unfollow you everyday without posting a worst content.

Not seen this problem in any other application. In other social media application, even if I open the application after an year the followers count remains same . If someone follows it only increases which gives us more enthusiasm to do more. Unlike Instagram, which gives only disappointment.

Supporting Statistics

Meta Q4 2024
 **362M+**
Indian Users

Creator Gap
 **20.7%**
(Consume>>Create)

Google Play store
 **Rating: 4.3**
163M+

App Store
 **Rating: 4.7**
29M+

Overview

User Research

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User Research & Validation

52 Survey Responses Collected

10 USERS INTERVIEWED

6/10

Find creating Reels too 'Time Consuming'

4/10

Users have posted a reel
(All with a clear Purpose)

5/10

Users feel publically posting compromising
their privacy

4/10

Users struggle with editing tools and
features discovery

Akshara, 22yrs, Engineering Intern

"UI could be better.

Instagram doesn't really showcase all the features available for creating Reels, so I don't know about many of the tools and features I could use."

**Priyanka, 28yrs
Homemaker and Creator**

"I have literally no idea how monetisation works or how brands find me.

If instagram made that easier, I would put so much more into my videos."

Saurabh, 23yrs Postgraduate Student

"I feel strongly about my Privacy.

Posting publicly feels like a real risk to me. That's a big reason i've never posted anything."

Archana, 46yrs, Entrepreneur

"I recorded a Reel with a trending song, but by the time I had time to upload it, the **song was no longer trending**. So there was no point posting it at all."

Niyati, 21yrs, Engineering Student

"I felt Awkward watching myself back and couldn't get the audio timing right,
That completely killed my motivation to finish and post the reel."

Tejas, 16yrs, School Student

"Getting real money or cashback

is the only thing that would actually push me to post. Social stuff like friends encouraging me doesn't motivate me."

Interview Transcripts

Survey Response Sheet

Overview

User Research

User Journey

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Success Metrics



16- years - old Intimidated Perfectionist



Ishaan Verma

"Give me a reason worth my time and make it stupidly easy and I'll actually post."

Age: 16

Occupation: School Student, Class 11

Location: Mumbai (Metro City)

Personality

Impulsive

Validation-seeking

Trend-aware but not trend-setting

Easily bored

Privacy-concerns

Psychographics: Lifestyle

- Spends 2-4+ hours daily on Instagram, often opening the app 20+ times a day in short bursts between classes and homework.
- Heavily multi-platform, bounces between Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts depending on mood.
- Uses Reels primarily to kill time, relax, and follow habitual scroll patterns rather than for any specific goal.

Behaviour

- Watches passively in long, uninterrupted sessions; rarely engages beyond likes.
- Sees other people's polished Reels and assumes his own life "isn't interesting enough" to compare.

Pain Points

- Believes his everyday life is too mundane or unremarkable to be "post-worthy" content.
- Has zero intrinsic motivation to create watching feels complete in itself, so there's no felt gap to fill.
- Carries a quiet discomfort about being publicly visible online, even if he can't articulate it as a "privacy" concern.

Needs

- Instant rewards (badges, recognition, in-app perks) for posting the first Reel.
- Ready-made templates that make creation effortless.
- Private-first sharing to reduce fear and build confidence.

Overview

User Research

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Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics



20-year-old Content-Comfortable Bystander



Ananya Rao

"I'll post the moment it's effortless and my friends are doing it with me, not before."

Age: 20

Occupation: College Student (B.Com, 2nd year)

Location: Bengaluru

Personality

Passive

Observant

Trend-savvy

Reserved

Casual

Psychographics: Lifestyle

- Highly engaged Reels consumer, spending 30 min – 2+ hours daily across multiple sessions.
- Uses Reels as a mix of entertainment, trends, and learning.
- Regularly consumes content on both Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts, but never feels compelled to create.

Behaviour

- Scrolls for extended periods and enjoys content passively; content creation rarely crosses her mind.
- Attempted creating a Reel once but dropped off due to a confusing editing experience.
- More hesitant about being judged by classmates and friends.

Pain Points

- **Lack of motivation to create**- consuming Reels already fulfills her entertainment and discovery needs.
- **Social visibility concerns**- uncomfortable sharing content with classmates and close peers who may judge her attempts.
- **Creation friction**- confusing editing tools and workflows discourage completion

Needs

- Peer encouragement from friends makes creating feel worthwhile.
- A private or close-friends audience lowers the pressure of posting.
- Simple, guided editing helps turn intent into a published Reel.

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics



41- years- old Privacy-Conscious Viewer



Rajesh Kapoor

"Make it safe, make it meaningful, and make me not have to think about the technical part, only then will I post."

Age: 41

Occupation: Business Owner

Location: Jaipur (Tier 1 City)

Personality

Reserved

Risk-averse

Settled / low novelty-seeking

Privacy-conscious

Psychographics: Lifestyle

- Lightest and most controlled usage opens the app only 1-5 times a day for under 30 minutes total.
- Uses Reels for entertainment and some learning, often alongside Facebook for similar short-video content.
- Daily routine is dominated by business and family responsibilities, leaving little incidental time for the app.

Behaviour

- Watches in short, deliberate bursts rather than long passive sessions; treats Reels as a brief break, not a primary activity.
- Has the strongest and most settled "I'm just a viewer" identity.

Pain Points

- Highest stated privacy/safety concern of any group public visibility itself feels risky, not just embarrassing.
- No felt need or identity tied to content creation, "viewer" is a settled self-perception.
- Where interest does flicker, the unfamiliarity of editing tools and format conventions feels like an unnecessary learning curve at this life stage.

Needs

- Strong privacy controls shown before and during creation, with clear "who can see this" visibility.
- A zero-decision flow that minimizes editing and makes posting effortless.
- Relatable prompts tied to family or business, making content creation feel meaningful and worth repeating.

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

Competitive Differentiation Matrix

 Advantage  Neutral  Gap

Factor			
First-Time Creator Nudge	 Memory-based creation prompts	 No dedicated creator nudge	 Generic "Get Started" prompts
Speed to First Post	 One-tap auto-generated content	 Templates require manual editing	 AI-assisted draft generation
Psychological Safety	 Private, Friends, and Public sharing options	 No private-first Reels experience	 Primarily public/unlisted posting
Discovery for New Creators	 Smaller audience reach	 Strong non-follower distribution	 Highly competitive feed
Monetization Accessibility	 High eligibility thresholds	 Limited creator monetization access	 Early perks after subscriber milestones

Overall, the white space lies in reducing creator friction while increasing confidence. By combining AI-assisted creation with private-first sharing, the platform can uniquely empower first-time creators.

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

User Journey of Instagram

★★★★★ : Represents Engagement Level

Step 01: User opens the app



User Actions

Opens Instagram reflexively between classes, before sleep with no specific intent.

Goals

No specific goal, just reflex habit

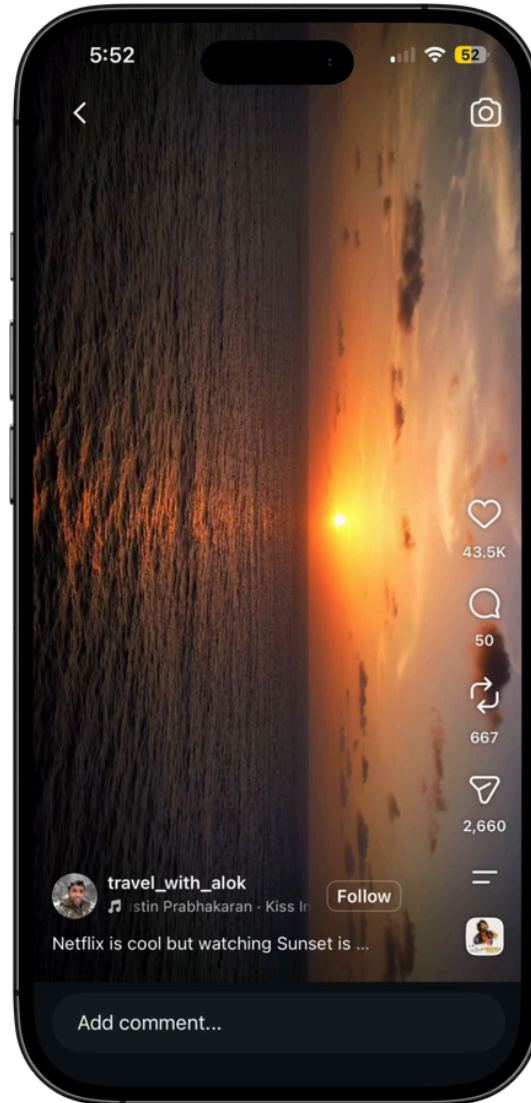
Pain Point + vs Youtube Shorts and Snapchat

YouTube opens directly to Shorts feed. Snapchat's camera opens by default : creation is the first gesture, not consumption. Instagram loses on this count.

Emotion

😐 ★★★★★

Step 02: Habitual browsing



User Actions

Scrolls Reels 15–45 min, double-tapping and replaying clips with no active goal. Exits and reopens 20 min later, repeats

Goals

Kill time and feel passively entertained

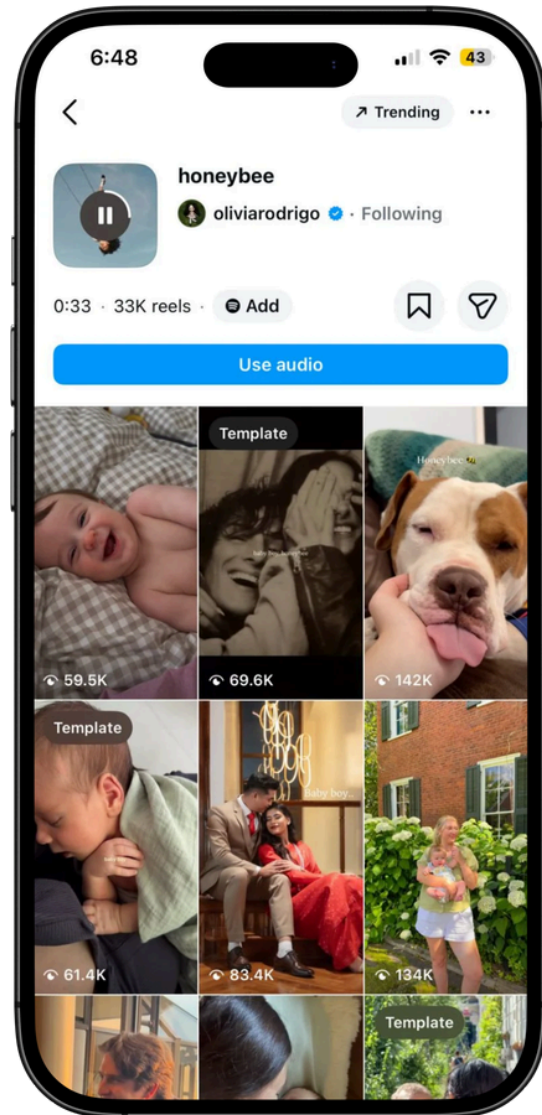
vs YouTube Shorts

YouTube Shorts embeds a "Create" shortcut mid-scroll after detecting session fatigue (20+ min).

Emotion

😊 ★★★★★

Step 03: The Spark



User Actions

Watches a relatable Reel twice, taps the audio, scrolls through others' versions, quietly exits back to feed

Goals

Discover whether "I could actually do something like this" fleeting creative curiosity

Pain Point

Creative spark evaporates in under 10 seconds, tapping the audio just opens other people's versions, not a creation prompt. There is no "save this idea" mechanism

Emotion

🤔 ★★★★★½

Overview

User Research

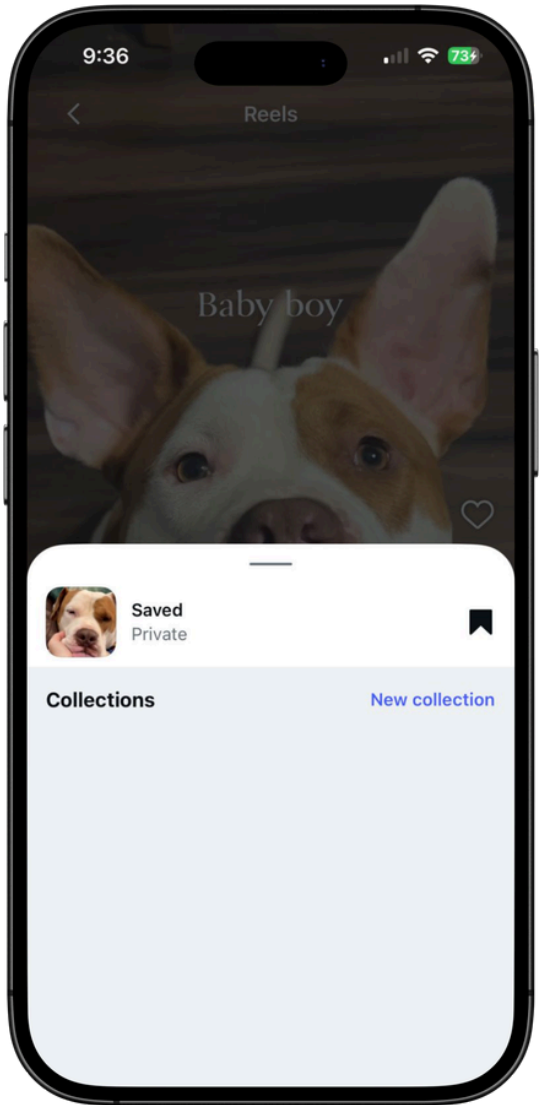
User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

User Journey of Instagram

Step 04: The Maybe pile



User Actions

Saves the audio or bookmarks the Reel, mentally filing it as "inspiration for later" with no concrete plan to act

Goals

Keep the idea "alive" just enough to feel like a creator, without the risk of actually becoming one

Pain Point

Bookmarking audio creates an illusion of progress i.e. the idea feels "handled" so urgency to act dies. No follow-through trigger exists

Emotion



Step 05: The Leap



User Actions

Taps Create for the first time, stares at an empty camera screen with no idea where to start. Taps timer, speed, effects, gets confused, abandons the draft mid-edit

Goals

Turn the fleeting idea into a finished Reel, runs into a wall and stops

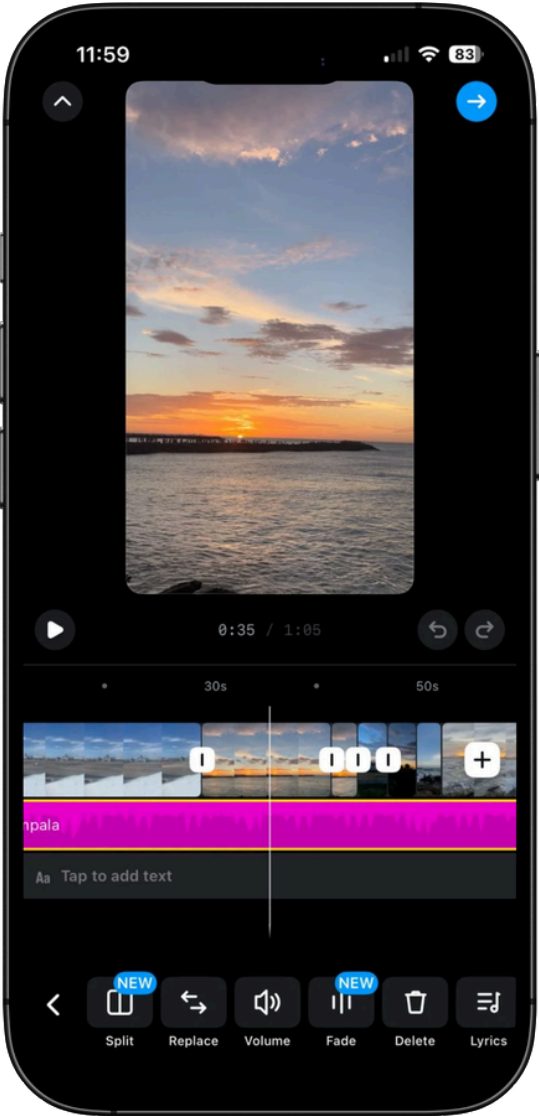
Pain Point

"Empty camera screen with zero guidance is a cliff edge for first-timers. Timer, speed, effects, align, ghost: all visible simultaneously with no hierarchy or sequence.

Emotion



Step 06: The Build



User Actions

Spends way longer than expected reshooting clips, struggling with the editor, second-guessing the caption and cover image, debating whether to even add their face

Goals

Match the quality of what they've been watching for months

Pain Point

Fear of college friends, cousins, and relatives seeing an imperfect first attempt. Default audience is fully public feels like performing on stage with no rehearsal

Emotion



Overview

User Research

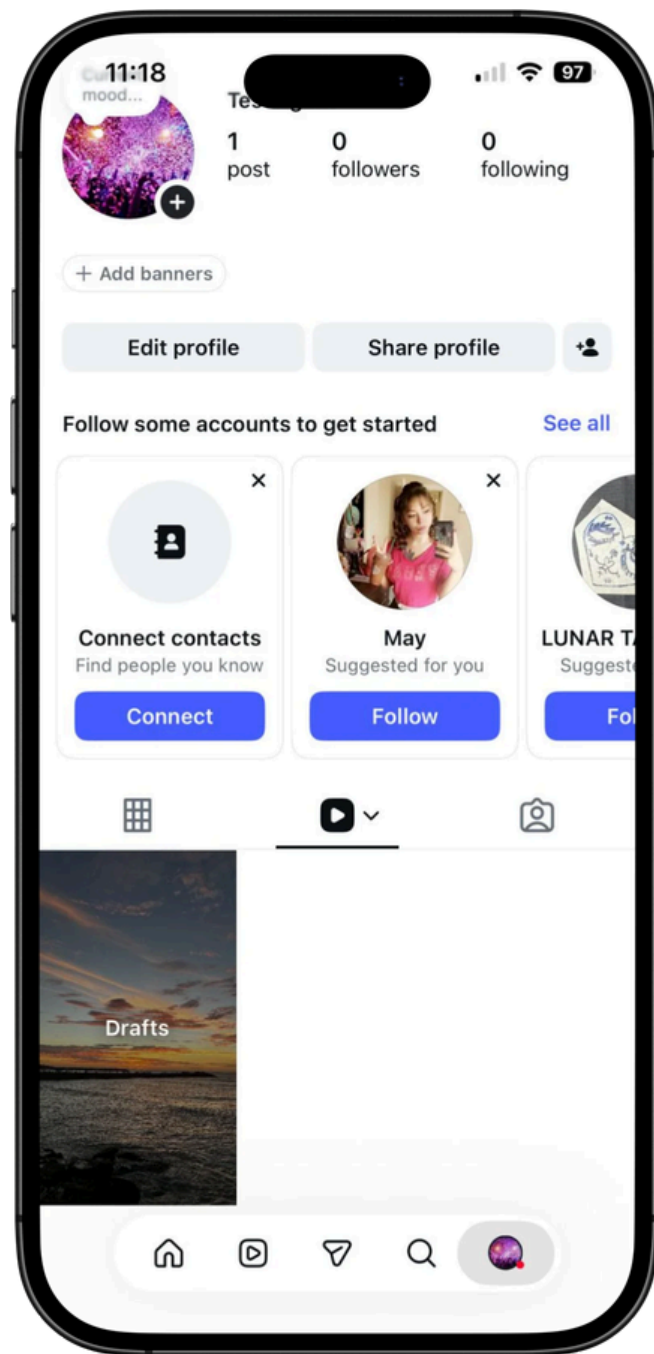
User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

User Journey of Instagram

Step 07: Draft purgatory



User Actions

Finishes editing but saves to drafts instead of posting, telling themselves they'll "fix it later" or "wait for the right time"

Goals

Feel the safety of having created something without the vulnerability of anyone seeing it, the draft becomes a comfort object

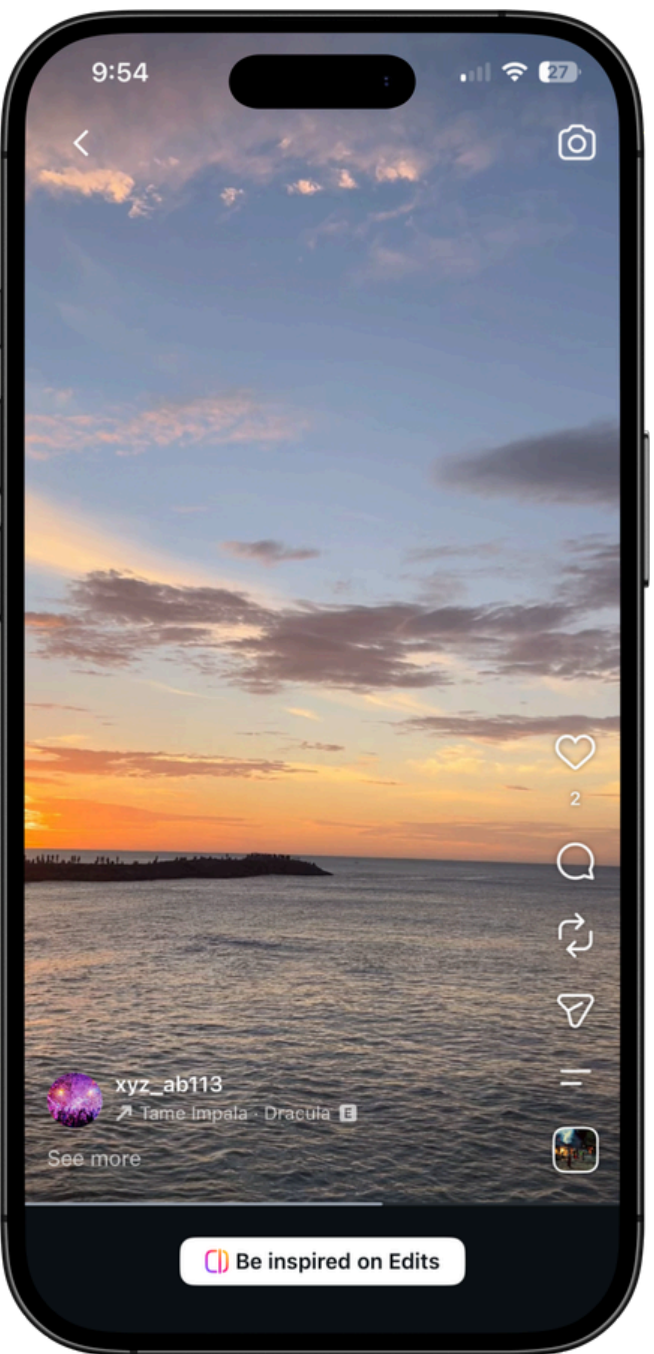
Pain Point

"Instagram does send draft re-engagement notifications but the notification opens a blank editor, not a guided 'finish this in 3 steps' flow. The nudge exists; the landing experience after the nudge is what completely fails. The user is dropped back into the same overwhelming screen that made them stop in the first place"

Emotion



Step 08: The Refresher Loop



User Actions

User finally posts, then immediately opens the Reel to check views, puts the phone down, picks it back up, checks again. Refreshes every few minutes for the first hour.

Goals

To get external validation that the leap was worth it, desperately hoping the numbers prove they belong here

vs Youtube Shorts

YouTube Shorts sends a re-engagement notification for saved drafts, "You left something unfinished" with a direct deep link.

Emotion



Overview

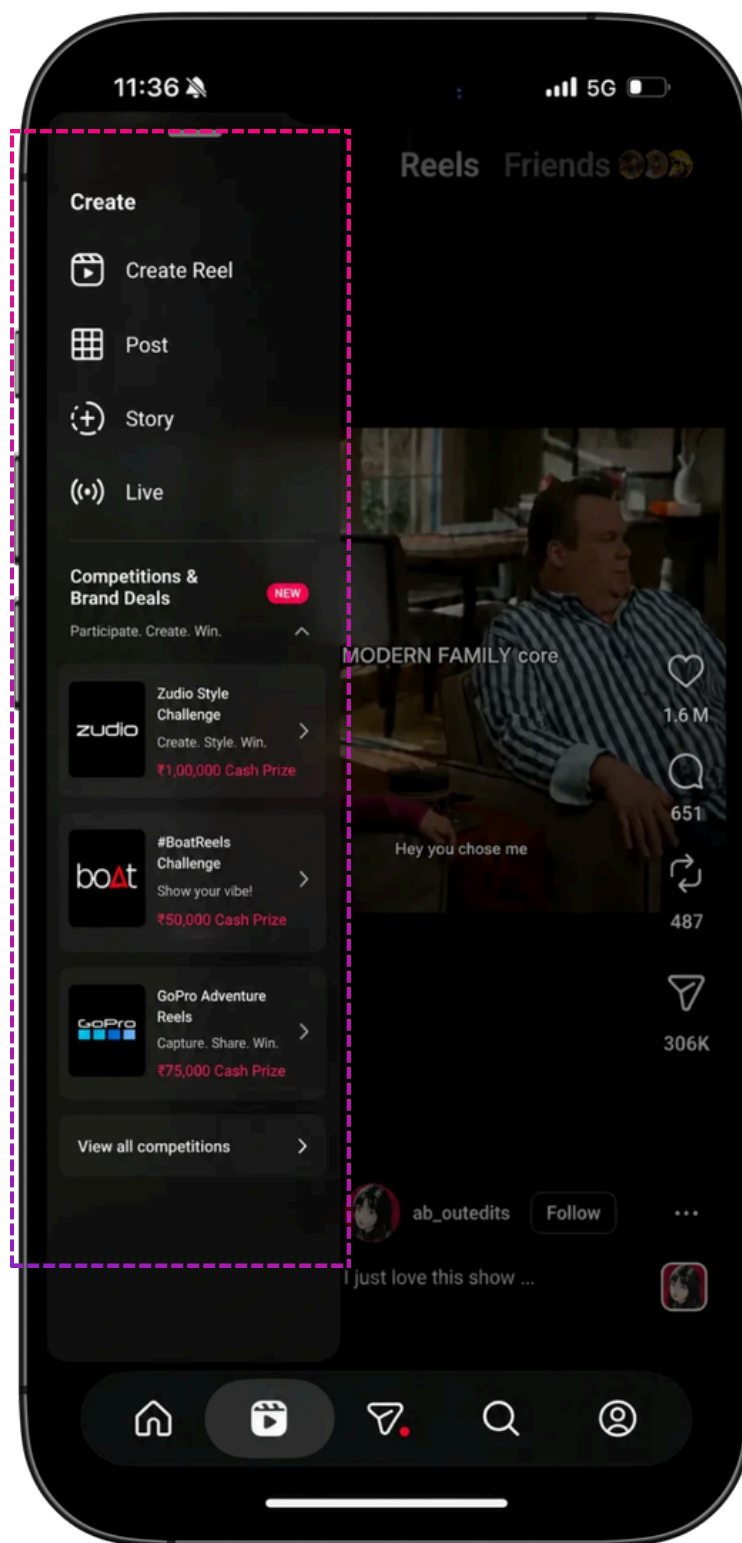
User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

New Feature Suggestions [Video Link to the prototype](#)



1.

Feature

BRAND CHALLENGES HUB

Story 1: As a passive Reels viewer, I want a reason to post my first Reel, so that effort feels worth it.

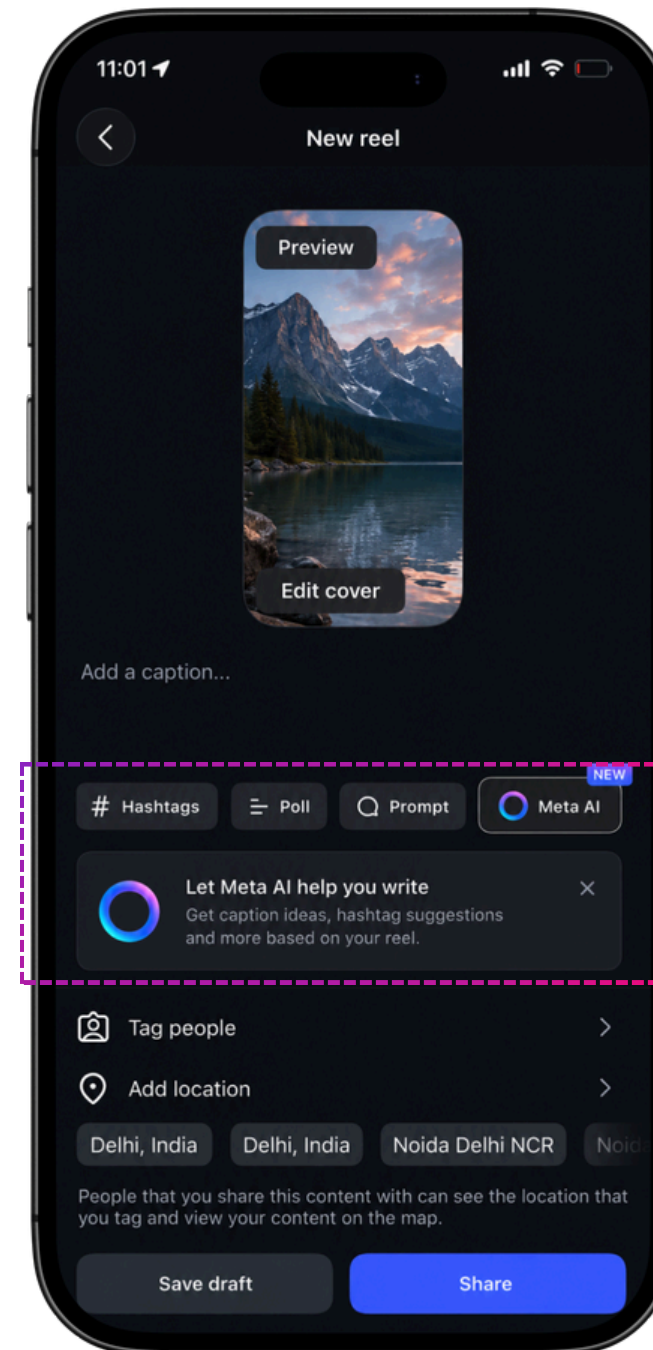
Tasks:

- Add a **Brand Challenges** tab listing active brand competitions **with clear prizes (cash, vouchers, products)**.
- Winners get **featured on the brand's page** + a permanent "**Challenge Winner**" badge on their own profile, adding social proof beyond just the prize.

Story 2: As a brand, I want to run a competition that drives real engagement, so my campaign reach justifies the spend.

Tasks:

- **Self-serve Challenge Listing page** where brands set prize pool, hashtag, and submission rules.
- **Paid placement tiers** - Brands can pay Instagram to get their challenge featured at the top.
- **Real-time entry leaderboard** visible to all participants

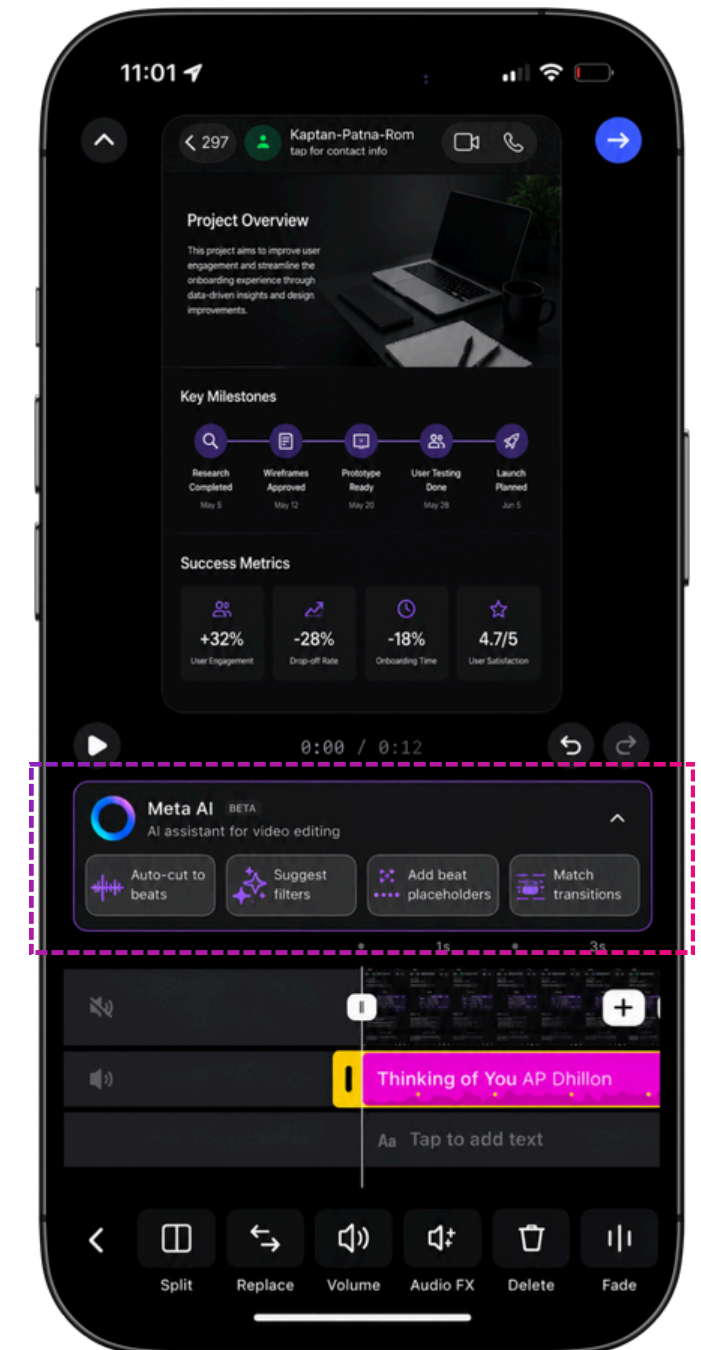


2.

Feature

META AI ASSISTANT FOR USERS

- **Smart Hashtag and caption Recommendations based on** reel's content, location and audio.
- Meta AI **analyzes your video, audio, and timeline** to automatically improve your edit.



Overview

User Research

User Journey

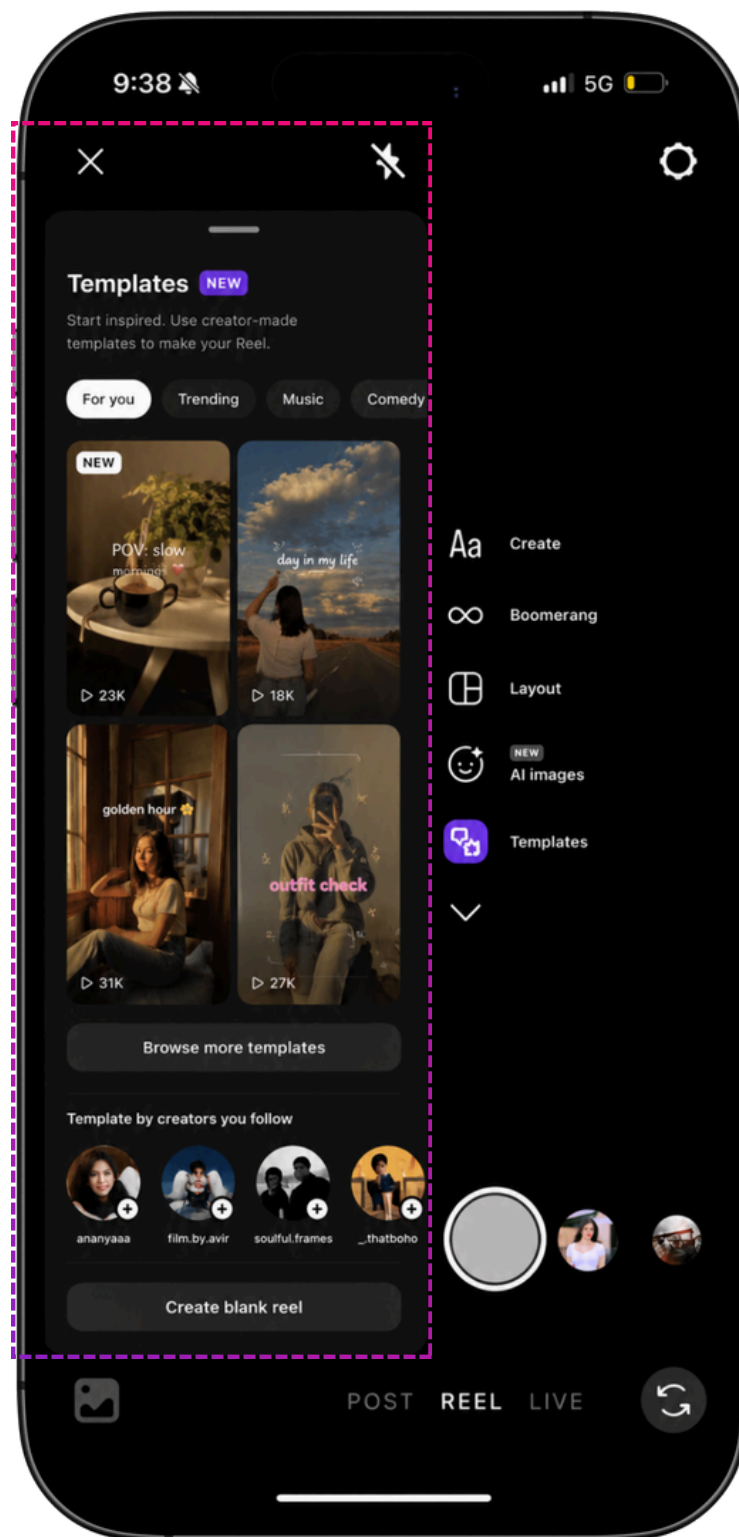
Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics



New Feature Suggestions

[Video Link to the prototype](#)



Overview

3.

Feature

TEMPLATES HUB

Story 1: As a passive Reels viewer, I want a starting point to create my first Reel without needing editing skills.

Tasks:

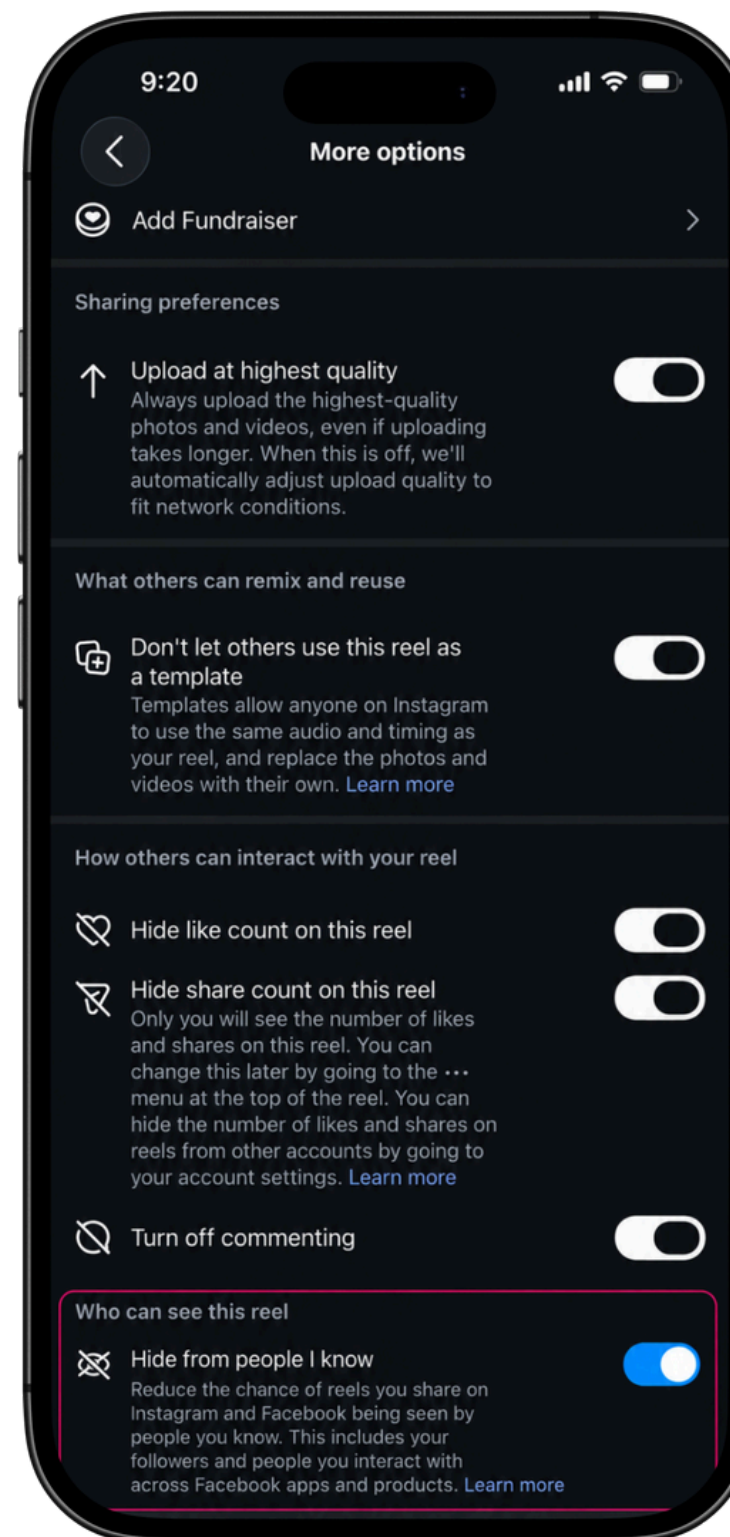
- A New **Templates icon** in the Home top nav that opens a **gallery of creator-made templates**, browsable by trending, audio, and category.
- The template is loaded with **pre-loaded cuts, transitions, and text placeholders**. User only adds their own clip and posts.

Story 2: As a creator, I want to be rewarded for making templates that others use, so I'm motivated to keep contributing.

Tasks:

- Auto-attach a "**Template by @creator**" tag on every Reel made using their template, driving **free profile traffic back** to the creator.
- Award a "**Top Template Creator**" badge once a template crosses a certain number of uses, **surfacing the original creator** to viewers of derivative Reels.

User Research



User Journey

4.

Feature

HIDE FROM PEOPLE I KNOW

Story : As a first-time poster, I want to share a Reel without my known contacts seeing it, so I feel safe posting without judgment

Tasks:

- When enabled, **suppress the Reel** from appearing **in the Following feed of phone-contact-matched followers**, and exclude it from being surfaced to non-follower phone contacts via suggestions/mutuals.
- Reel still **distributes normally to the algorithmic/Explore Reels feed**, so reach isn't lost.
- Extend the hide rule to the **profile grid**, matched contacts visiting the profile directly **don't see the hidden Reel either**.
- Show a clear **in-app indicator (e.g., small eye-off icon on the post)** so the user can verify and manage which of their Reels are contact-hidden, and **toggle it off later once they're comfortable**.

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

Estimated Impact Analysis

Impact of proposed features on creator activation among zero-post users in India



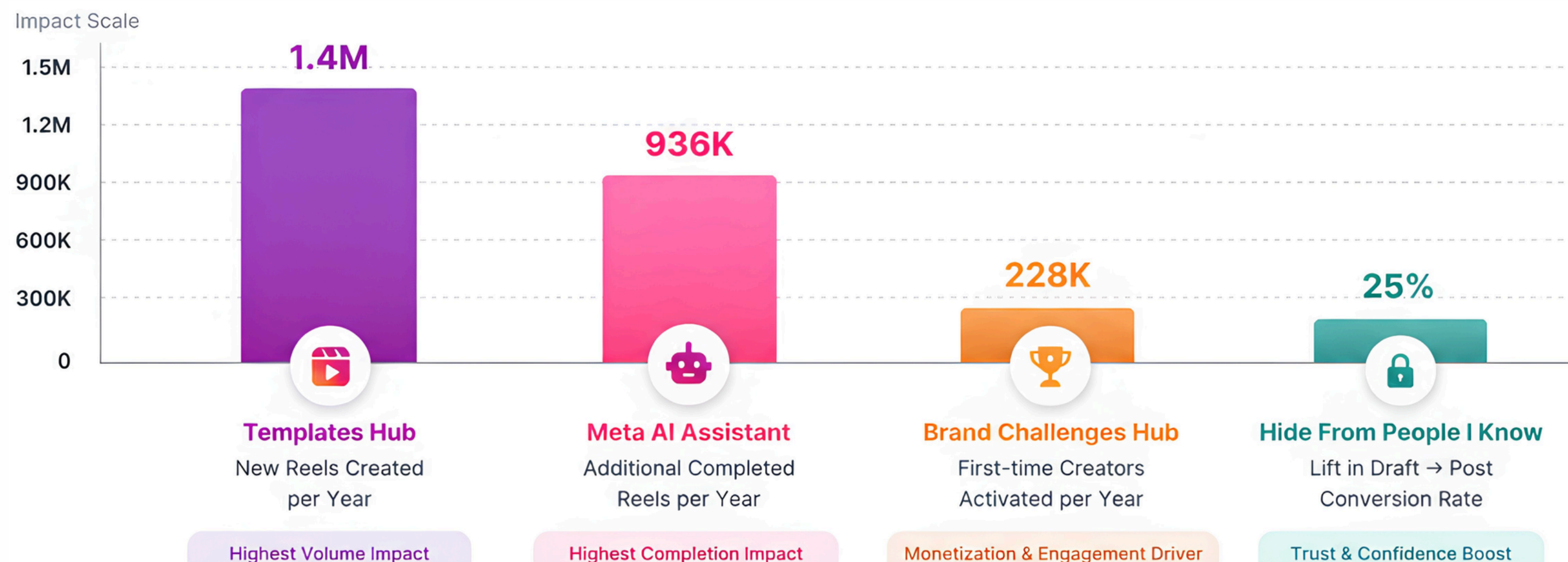
Key Insight

These features address different barriers across the creator journey, driving meaningful lift in first-time Reel creation.

Basis of Estimates

- 130M Reels DAU in India | 117M zero-post users (90%)
- Primary interviews (n=10) & secondary research
- Conservative guesstimates
- All figures represent incremental annual impact

Estimated Annual Impact by Feature *(Detailed estimate in the Appendix)*



What this means

Collectively, these features improve every stage of the creator journey; motivation, creation, editing, and posting confidence; resulting in higher creator activation and long-term engagement.

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

Feature Tradeoffs

Evaluating the key benefits and risks of each proposed feature



Goal:

Maximize first-time Reel creation by reducing creator friction while balancing implementation risks.

Impact Potential

High

Strong impact on activation

Medium

Moderate impact with dependencies

Low

Lower direct impact or higher risk



1. Brand Challenges Hub

✓ Benefits

- Creates strong motivation for zero-post users to take the first step
- Drives brand participation and opens new revenue stream
- Showcases talent and improves creator discovery

✗ Risks

- Low-quality or spam submissions can dilute campaign value
- Small creators may feel outcompacted by influencers
- Requires ongoing brand partnerships and moderation

Impact Potential:

Medium



2. Meta AI Assistant

✓ Benefits

- Reduces editing friction; major drop-off point for new creators
- Auto-captions, beat sync & edits reduce time-to-post
- Helps users create higher-quality Reels with less effort

✗ Risks

- Over-reliance may lead to similar content and reduce originality
- Privacy concerns if AI processes private or draft content
- High compute cost and misuse risk

Impact Potential:

High



3. Templates Hub

✓ Benefits

- Lower skill barrier; anyone can create with templates
- Encourages talented creators to build and share templates
- Scales content variety quickly

✗ Risks

- Feed may become repetitive if few templates dominate
- Low-effort templates may flood the platform
- Quality control and curation needed

Impact Potential:

High



4. Hide From People I Know

✓ Benefits

- Removes fear of judgment from friends and family
- Increases confidence to post first Reel
- Reel remains discoverable via algorithm

✗ Risks

- Contact matching may incorrectly hide content
- Could be misused to avoid accountability
- May reduce organic sharing among known networks

Impact Potential:

Medium

Overall Takeaway

Each feature tackles a unique barrier in the creator journey; motivation, creation ease, skills, and social confidence. Together, they create a comprehensive solution to drive first-time Reel creation.

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

Success Metrics Framework

Measuring what matters to drive first-time Reel creation and long-term creator growth



North Star Metric



Reels Activation Rate

% of zero-post Indian users who publish their first Reel within 30 days of feature exposure

Captures both the problem we're solving and Instagram's creator supply growth



Why it matters?

Direct indicator of our core goal: activating new creators and expanding the Reels ecosystem.

L1 Metrics

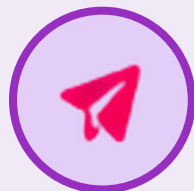


1. FIRST REEL PUBLISH RATE

% of users who open the creator flow and complete a post



Core Activation Metric



2. DRAFT-TO-POST CONVERSION RATE

% of saved drafts that get published, directly targets draft purgatory



Quality of intent

L2 Metrics

TEMPLATE USAGE RATE

% of first-time creators who used a Templates Hub template

Feature Adoption

BRAND CHALLENGE ENTRY RATE

% of zero-post users who submit a challenge entry

Engagement & Discovery

"HIDE FROM CONTACTS" TOGGLE RATE

How many first-time posters enable this before posting

Trust & Confidence

CREATOR FLOW DROP-OFF BY STEP

Where users abandon, pinpoints step 5 "The Leap" friction

Fiction Diagnosis

Overview

User Research

User Journey

Feature Suggestions

Success Metrics

Thank You

Ready to convert consumers into creators.

Appendix

Appendix A: Impact Analysis – Brand Challenges Hub

Feature 1: Brand Challenges Hub

Assumptions

Parameter	Value	Rationale
India Reels DAU	130M	Secondary research
Zero-post users	90% (117M)	90-9-1 participation rule
Challenge awareness	15%	Conservative reach
Submission rate	1%	Typical UGC campaign
Challenge cycles/year	2	Limited high-quality
Repeat participation	35%	Removes duplicate

130M × 90% = 117M Zero-post users

117M × 15%
= 17.55M users exposed

17.55M × 1%
= 175,500 challenge entries

175,500 × 2
= 351,000 annual entries

351,000 × (1 – 35%)
= 228,150 unique first-time creators

Estimated Annual Impact
≈ 228K New First-Time Reel Creators

Appendix B: Impact Analysis – Meta AI Assistant

Feature 2: Meta AI Assistant

Assumptions

Parameter	Value
Zero-post users	117M
Users opening Creator Flow	8%
Current completion rate	20%
Completion with AI	30%

117M × 8%
= 9.36M users attempt creation

Current
9.36M × 20%
= 1.87M completed posts

With Meta AI
9.36M × 30%
= 2.81M completed posts

Incremental Impact
2.81M – 1.87M
= 936K additional completed posts

Estimated Annual Impact
≈ 936K Additional Reels

Appendix C: Impact Analysis – Templates Hub

Feature 3: Templates Hub

Assumptions

Parameter	Value
Zero-post users	117M
Monthly template visits	5%
Browse → Post conversion	2%
Months/year	12

117M × 5%
= 5.85M monthly users

5.85M × 2%
= 117K monthly posts

117K × 12
= 1.404M annual posts

Estimated Annual Impact
≈ 1.4M New Reels

Appendix D: Impact Analysis – Hide From People I Know

Feature 4: Hide From People I Know

Assumptions

Parameter	Value	Source
Users blocked by privacy concerns	50%	Primary interviews
Recovery after feature introduction	50%	Primary + secondary research

50%
Users hesitate because of social judgment

↓
50%
Recover after enabling
Hide From Contacts

↓
25%
Net Draft → Post
Conversion Lift

Estimated Annual Impact
≈ 25% Improvement in Draft → Post Conversion